Very soon, I got an opportunity to satisfy the GOC's curiosity. Based on some intelligence inputs, we launched a cordon-and-search operation in a village named Fatehgarh on the way to Uri. Furthermore, we organized and played an impromptu cricket match with the young men of Fatehgarh. Much to the delight of the village youth, after a friendly ten-over game, we presented the cricket gear to them and shared a cup of tea with them. Such a thing was quite a rarity in those days, and the GOC's staff almost went into a state of consternation when the idea was first mooted. But the general went back suitably impressed.

So what exactly was our modus operandi in 79 Mountain Brigade when we conducted a cordon-and-search operation, including the famous 'khopdi' drill?

The first step was always to get the maximum information on the terrorists' activities and their presence in a given area, and more importantly, to get actionable intelligence in real time. Sometimes this intelligence would come from our own sources and at other times, from the higher HQs. Frequently, the commanding general would call me to his office or residence, and we would discuss and work out the broad operational plan based on the information provided by the sources. Before meeting the general, I would issue the warning order for the mission to the unit concerned.

This would set in motion the preparations for the operation by the troops. With an aim of deception, the vehicles were lined up facing the wrong direction. Very often I would order the movement to be on foot all the way to the target – a rapid march at night covering up to 20 kilometres or so. Surprise is indeed critical for success and in my opinion, it is one of the most important principles of war. In fact, I advised all junior leaders to ask themselves whether the plan they had evolved had an element of surprise or not. In case the answer was 'no', that plan would have to be trashed and a new one devised.

Generally, the plan involved convergence on the objective from two or three directions. The outer cordon would be established well before first light and the noose tightened at twilight. This kind of encircling action confused the terrorists, and made it difficult for